

BEFORE

Prior to the rise of Islam, the Arabian Peninsula consisted of loosely organized federations of peoples and towns.

BEFORE ISLAM

The Arabian Peninsula has always been dominated by sparsely populated, arid desert. Its early inhabitants were mainly nomads such as the **Bedouin**, although there were some farmers around the oases. The few towns were trading centers for goods such as spices. Frankincense, a fragrant tree resin, was one of the most important products. The proximity of the **Silk Road 184–85** made it relatively easy for Arabian merchants to trade their goods.

FRANKINCENSE

PRE-ISLAMIC RELIGION

Pre-Islamic Arabs spoke a number of languages and followed a variety of religions, most of which were polytheistic, worshipping several different gods **144–45**. **Mecca**, later the most important religious site of Islam, was already a center of worship.

MUHAMMAD THE PROPHET

Muhammad was a merchant based at Mecca when he had his first revelation from God. Although some people accepted his teachings, the hostility of others forced him into **exile in Medina**. There, he gathered more followers, uniting the local tribes and raiding caravans until he managed to conquer Mecca itself. By Muhammad's death in 632 CE, the whole of the Arabian Peninsula was united under the new Islamic religion. The followers of Muhammad—Muslims—then **expanded** farther **toward Syria**, which brought them in contact with the two great empires of Persia and Byzantium.

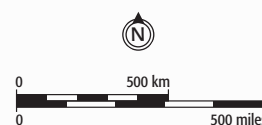


The spread of Islam

The followers of Muhammad spread out from their Arabian homeland with startling speed in the century or so after the prophet's death. By the mid-8th century, they had reached as far as Spain, stretching the extent of the caliphate to breaking point.

KEY

- Muslim lands by 634
- Muslim lands by 656
- Muslim lands by 756
- Byzantine Empire c. 610
- Sassanian Empire c. 610
- Frankish Kingdoms c. 610



The Ascent of Islam

In 622 CE, Muhammad was forced into exile in Medina from Mecca for his beliefs. By 750, these beliefs had become the basis of a religion whose adherents governed an area stretching continuously from the borders of China to Spain. By 1450 Muslims were ruling in areas as far east as Indonesia.

Following the death of Muhammad in 632 CE, his successors, who were known as caliphs, carried Islam far beyond the confines of the Arabian Peninsula. Shortly after the death of the second caliph 'Umar ibn 'Abd al-Khattab in 644, the Muslims conquered the entire Persian Empire (see pp.122–23), as well as taking Syria and Egypt from the Byzantine Empire (see pp.198–99). The new rulers were tolerant toward the religions they found in their conquered territories, and did not force conversion. The constantly expanding area of the Islamic Empire was controlled by governors based in armed camps, each taking their instructions from Medina.

Despite their military successes, the Muslims were soon split by factional differences. The most remote



governors were constantly trying to become independent, and there was tension between the “true” followers of Muhammad and those they believed were simply hungry for power. Things came to a head with the murder in 656 of the third caliph, 'Uthman ibn 'Affan, which led to outright civil war between 'Ali ibn abi Talib, a relative of Muhammad himself, and Mu'awiya ibn Abi Sufyan, a relative of the murdered 'Uthman. When 'Ali was

Kaaba

This 16th-century Turkish tile depicts the Kaaba at Mecca. Originally a site of pre-Islamic polytheistic worship, this square building is the holiest site in Islam, and all Muslims pray toward it.

assassinated in 661, Mu'awiya took power, becoming the first caliph of the Umayyad dynasty.

Although this turbulent period saw a great deal of conflict, it also witnessed the collation and standardization of the Qur'an, the Muslim holy book. The second caliph even introduced a new Islamic “Hijri” calendar, which kept time by following the cycles of the moon, and dated its years from the time of Muhammad's flight to Medina.

The Umayyad dynasty

The Umayyads took their name from the clan to which the first Umayyad caliph, Mu'awiya ibn Abi Sufyan, belonged.